# Our Culture Hates Fat People - A Collection

## By Rachel Wiley and Donna Ashworth

## INTRODUCTION

*Poet and body positive activist Rachel Wiley wants to change the way we look at fatness. For years as a performer and poet, Wiley did not address this topic, she said,"I think I subconsciously thought, 'Oh, if I don't talk about my fat, nobody else will notice.'"*

*The time to be silent has passed. An article in Scientific American* puts it best: "We can no longer pretend that being less likely to be hired . . . being paid less, receiving biased medical treatment, being socially excluded and bullied are attempts to help people "be healthier." These are the direct consequences of living in a culture that vilifies and fears fat bodies and that treats the people living in them as morally lesser beings."*

*Our Culture Hates Fat People – A Collection by Rachel Wiley and Donna Ashworth, including For Fat Girls Who Considered Starvation When Bulimia Wasn't Enough, The Fat Joke and When You Cannot Bear Your Body*

4NG Fanatics

## For Fat Girls Who Considered Starvation When Bulimia Wasn't Enough by Rachel Wiley

**(Pg 76-77)** Mom says that my teeth are perfect
Perfect brother has just gotten braces on his top four front
teeth
a tiny railroad bridge connecting nothing
and mom says that my teeth are perfect.
At last my quiet mouth, the overlook, the swallowed
feelings have all paid off
and cultured something perfect
and mine.
My mouth is a music box
stuffed with pearls.

Perfect brother is tall
and lean
eats whatever he wants.
One time a whole box of oatmeal cream pies.
But it is clearer each day that my baby fat
is no longer baby fat
but just fat
It is clearer each day that I will not be a ballerina.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

I had wanted to be a ballerina.
My mouth is a music box
A small girl spins gracefully at the back of my throat
on point
I am sure if I can just reach far enough back I could still
have her grace
I reach for her every night after dinner while the bathtub
fills.

Until one day the health teacher shows us a photo
of a mouth crammed full of broken, yellowed dishes
says that a side effect of Bulimia
is ruined teeth
but Mom said that my teeth were perfect.
And my perfect is a ransom I cannot bring myself to pay
for the spinning girl
so I swallow her
and then nothing more for 4 whole days.
My mouth is a music box,
plays a low gear grinding that puts me to sleep.

When I do not wake up any closer to being a spinning girl

4NG Fanatics

encircled in pink tulle
but rather still a ravenous hollow encircled in overgrowth
I sneak down to the pantry and devour an entire box of
oatmeal cream pies in the dark
before going upstairs to brush my perfect teeth 1 at a time.

## The Fat Joke by Rachel Wiley

**(Pg 22-23)** The old joke goes:
Patient walks into the doctor's office and says, "Doctor
it hurts when I move my arm like this, what should I do?
and the doctor says, "So, don't move your arm like that"

Now,

Fat Girl walks into the doctor's office and says, "Doctor
it hurts
when I move my arm like this, what should I do?" and the
doctor
says, "Have you considered weight loss surgery?"
Fat Girl walks into the doctor for a flu shot
and gets a lecture about BMI

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

Fat Girl walks into the doctor's for an earache and gets asked if
she's ever eaten a salad
Fat Girl walks into the doctor's office with a spider bite and the
doctor obsesses over how low her blood pressure is -- low, for such a
fat person anyway – and insists on checking it 3 times before he
believes it, has to be reminded of the purple mass of throbbing spider
venom that brought her here in the first place
Fat Girl walks into the doctor's to ask about antidepressants
and gets prescribed exercise instead
Fat Girl walks into the doctor's office for a standard 3-month followup
appointment and the doctor says, "Have you considered that weight
loss surgery?
Fat Girl gets tired of only ever being diagnosed as fat
so Fat Girl stops walking into the doctor's office.

4NG Fanatics

Fat Girl walks to the store
and has insults flicked at her like still-lit
cigarettes from passing cars
Fat Girl walks onto a crowded bus and stands because she does not
wish to share a seat and make anyone else uncomfortable

Fat Girl logs onto the internet, gets comments from keyboard doctors
that claim concern for her health
suggests crash diets
suggests flat-tummy tea
suggests diet pills that would stop fat girls' heart, but fat girl will have
died trying to get thin
Fat Girl walks into the world and says,
"World it hurts to exist like this."
World says, "So stop existing like that"
World says, "have you considered weight loss surgery?"
Would rather she slice herself open than to exist as she does
side-effects be damned

Despite all of this, Fat Girl still manages to love her fat body
World says, “Stop glorifying obesity.”
Fat Girl walks up to World, says, “I do not owe you shrinking, you
know. I do not owe you thinness, attempted thinness, or desired
thinness because you assume thinness equals health. I do not owe you
health, perceived or otherwise, to receive basic respect. I am
deserving of existence. I am deserving of care. I am deserving of first no harm done.”
World says,
“That is the best joke we’ve heard all day.”

## SOURCE INFORMATION

***Author: Rachel Wiley***
***Book: Nothing is Okay***
***ISBN: 978-1943735303***
***Publisher: Button Poetry***
***Date (Month/Year): March 2018***

FOR EDUCATIONAL

4NG Fanatics

## When You Cannot Bear Your Body by Donna Ashworth

The days when you cannot bear to exist within your own body, are the days you must really sit there and feel the vessel you live in.
Consider its structure, the layers, the insides.
The many miraculous functions it carries out in every moment.
If it lives with disability, consider the pressure that brings to each and every sinew.
If it is fighting illness, imagine that war within you.
Stare at your body, absorb it. Touch it.
Let the feelings of shame and disgust engulf you, and then send them away to the universe to dispose of.
You are not your body.
You are a guest in your body and you are currently rejecting it daily, hourly.
This rejection creates disfunction and estrangement.
It is little wonder you feel uncomfortable within your own skin.
You are.
You, my friend, did not ruin your body, or let yourself go.

You are merely living, and life takes its toll, as it absolutely must.

The days when you cannot bear to exist within your body, are the days when your body needs you, so very much, to check in.

To accept.

To apologize.

To connect.

To befriend.

Be grateful, as every guest should be.

Be tidy, be respectful, be clean.

But most of all, be good company.

You are not here for long.

## SOURCE INFORMATION

***Author: Donna Ashworth***
***Book: Life***
***ISBN: 978-1785304446***
***Publisher: Black and White Publishing***
***Date (Month/Year): October 2022***

## AWARD HISTORY

***2020 National Qualifier – MS as a Collection***
***2024 National Qualifier – Fat Joke by R Wiley only***
***KS State Qualifier – As a Collection***

4NG Fanatics

***NOTE: Only the 2 poems by Rachel Wiley were presented for the Award History listed.***

**** Source information for information contained in the introduction:***

***Article Title: Fat is Not the Problem Stigma Is***
***Authors: Linda Bacon and Amee Severson***
***Magazine: Scientific American***
***Posted On-line: July 8, 2019***
***https://blogs.scientificamerican.com/observations/fat-is-not-the-problem-fat-stigma-is/#***

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY